My Baby

By Robert Mauro

CHARACTERS: *KATE, a surrogate mother; MIRIAM, her best friend.*
Scene 1 TIME: *Today.*
SETTING: *A lounge in a hospital. There is a sign that reads MATERNITY WARD with an arrow pointing Stage Left. There is a NO SMOKING sign and we can hear the intercom paging doctors.*
AT RISE: *KATE and MIRIAM are sitting on a couch, not talking, but looking straight ahead.*

MIRIAM: Katie?

KATE: No. I just can't. I just cannot. I'm sorry, Miriam. I know I promised you, but I just can't.

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INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS 1: *What happens when a surrogate mother changes her mind?*
ACTRESS 2: *In a legal sense, the arrangements are legally binding and usually occur between strangers.*
ACTRESS 1: *In My Baby by Robert Mauro, however, the arrangement are made without legal counsel and between lifelong friends.*
ACTRESS 2: *Miriam and Katie – Miriam is married and desperately wants a child.*
ACTRESS 1: *Katie is unattached, financially strapped and willing to do anything to help her best friend.*
ACTRESS 2: *Until the baby arrives, then emotions rapidly change and the lifetime friendship is stretched to its limits.*
TOGETHER: *My Baby by Robert Mauro*

KATE: I know what I said. I know I promised you and Peter. But when I saw her this morning, when I held her in my arms.

MIRIAM: But we're friends. You promised. You're my best friend. All these years we've been friends. Since we were kids. And you've never broken a promise. Never. Not to me.

KATE: Don't you think I know that?

MIRIAM: *(Gets up and paces)* We were always best friends. We always helped each other out. We were always there for each other. Remember?

KATE: I haven't forgotten, Miriam. How could I forget? God, we're like sisters.

MIRIAM: More than sisters. I told you things I never told my sisters. We were so close.

KATE: We still are. I still love you. *(She stands and goes to put her arm on MIRIAM's shoulder, but MIRIAM pulls away.)* Miriam?

MIRIAM: You promised! How could you do this to me? How could you?

KATE: *(Sitting back down)* I don't know. I didn't think I would, especially not having a husband - or a boyfriend, for that matter. But then I saw her.

MIRIAM: I saw her, too. How do you think I feel? Do you have any idea how I feel, Kate? Do you?

KATE: I know. It must hurt.

MIRIAM: Hurt? That's an understatement. After all these months of planning and dreaming and waiting. Did you do any of that?

KATE: Well ... No, I guess not ... But ... I don't know. I did want to give you something, I was doing it for you, but ...

MIRIAM: But what? You're telling me you weren't sure even then?

KATE: I thought I was. When you asked me that night at my place, remember how I hugged you? *(MIRIAM nods.)* I thought, wow, what a great idea. And you picked me. I was so happy. I think I loved you more than . . . than ever before. I was so happy.

MIRIAM: Yeah. So was I.

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KATE: Oh . . . Mir, I so much wanted to make you happy. I thought what a sweet thing to do for my best friend. This was like the ultimate gift, you know?

MIRIAM: I thought I knew.

KATE: *(She gets up and paces.)* You did. We both did. What more could I do for the friend who always stood by me when guys dumped me or when my parents were killed. It was always you. You were always there for me. Right? I still love you. It's just that I love her too ... I can't give her up.

MIRIAM: Katie, it wouldn't be like you'd never see her again. Hey, we practically live together. We're together more than Peter and I. So you'd always be there - now for both of us, instead of just me.

KATE: Miriam, I can't.

MIRIAM: You can't what? You can't give her to me or we can't be friends anymore?

KATE: Please don't say that. *(KATE sits down.)* You know we'll always be friends. *(MIRIAM turns her back on KATE.)* Miriam? Right? We'll always be friends? Miriam? Say something.

MIRIAM: What is there left to say?

KATE: Say you still love me. Say we're still friends. Please. I need you - especially now.

MIRIAM: Why would you need me if you have her?

KATE: I'll always need you. Hey, you know me. Who'd take the knots out of my sneakers if I lost you? Huh? Half the time I can't do anything right.

MIRIAM: Well, you sure made a beautiful baby.

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KATE: *(She smiles.)* I did, didn't I?

MIRIAM: You sure did. And you promised her to me.

KATE: I know. *(Stands up and goes over to MIRIAM who walks to the other side of stage)* Miriam, don't do this to me. Don't do this to us.

MIRIAM: I'm not the one who's doing it.

KATE: And I am?

MIRIAM: You're the one who broke her promise.

KATE: I never meant to hurt you. It's just that after carrying her all these months, and then seeing her this morning, holding her. Have you held her yet?

MIRIAM: They wouldn't let me.

KATE: *(Walking over to MIRIAM)* Why not?

MIRIAM: They said only the mothers could hold the babies.

KATE: I'll talk to the nurse.

MIRIAM: No. That's all right.

KATE: You don't want me to talk to the nurse? Or you don't want to hold her?

MIRIAM: I don't know ... I don't know. When I see her I practically ... Now, after you did this, if I held her ...

KATE: But she'll love you, just like I do. Hey, you'll be like her second mom. Really. You'll see.

MIRIAM: *(Sitting on couch)* I'm really upset by all of this, Katie.

KATE: *(Sitting beside her)* I know. Mir, believe me, the last thing in the world I ever wanted to do was hurt you.

MIRIAM: Well, you sure did. You have no idea. I used to dream about this day, when I'd hold her for the first time. And all the things her and Peter and I would do.

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KATE: You and Peter and her?

MIRIAM: Oh, you'd be there, too. Like always. I promise.

KATE: *(Pulling away to other side of couch)* I feel terrible. I don't want to lose you over this. It's not fair.

MIRIAM: Fair? When is anything fair? Life's not fair. It's not fair your parents were killed in that plane crash, it's not fair that half the world goes to bed hungry, it's not fair that I can't have kids. Fair? What's fair?

KATE: I tried. I really did. Miriam?

MIRIAM: Katie, how could you do this to me after all I did for you? After all Peter and I did?

KATE: *(KATE stands up and paces.)* If you're trying to make me feel guilty, you have.

MIRIAM: *(Walks over to KATE)* Who paid all your doctor bills for the last nine months?

KATE: You and Peter.

MIRIAM: You're darn right. And who held you when you barfed up your guts every morning?

KATE: You did?

MIRIAM: You're darn right Because I loved you and wanted to be there for you. And I always was. Right?

KATE: Yes, yes, yes. What can I say? I feel terrible, but what can I do about it?

MIRIAM: You can give me your baby.

KATE: *(Pointing at her)* See?

MIRIAM: See what?

KATE: What you said. You called it *my* baby. Even you instinctively

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feel that. And so do I. It's my baby. It's like part of me, part of my very being. Part of my heart. Can I give my heart away?

MIRIAM: Look, all I know is that you signed all those papers and we paid all your doctor bills, and I took care of you.

KATE: Miriam, I'll pay you back. I promise. Every penny.

MIRIAM: Sure. Where will you get the money?

KATE: I have a job.

MIRIAM: A job? You call the popcorn girl at the local X-rated movie theater a job?

KATE: Sure. What would you call it?

MIRIAM: A temporary inconvenience, like all the other jobs you've had.

KATE: At least I work.

MIRIAM: Now what is that supposed to mean? Because I stay home and take care of the house while Peter works I'm no good? Is that what you're saying?

KATE: No, no, no. Look, I promise I'll pay you back.

MIRIAM: The money is not important. I don't care about the money, all right? It's the baby. You promised you'd give her to me. You promised.

KATE: I know.

MIRIAM: When you heard I couldn't have kids you promised to give me a baby.

KATE: I know. You were so depressed. I hate it when you're like that. I felt so heartbroken for you. It was the only thing I could think of to help you. Maybe I didn't know what I was getting into.

MIRIAM: Maybe.

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KATE: Right. You know me. I'm like a kid at times. I can't stand it when anyone is hurt. I can't even step on a bug. Remember that time you were terrified by that water bug? We saw it crossing your kitchen floor. You jumped up on a chair and screamed to me, "Kill it! Kill it!" And all I could do was sweep it out the door into the garden?

MIRIAM: I remember.

KATE: So you know if I couldn't hurt a water bug I could never hurt my dearest friend. *(MIRIAM is silent.)* Miriam? Do you believe me? *(KATE lays her hand on MIRIAM's back.)* Miriam? You know I love you.

MIRIAM: *(Hugs KATE.)* I know. I'm sorry, Katie. I'm sorry! But I wanted that baby so much.

KATE: *(Comforting her)* I know, I know. I didn't think I'd ever want a kid, but I do. I want this one. And I think now I know why.

MIRIAM: Why?

KATE: Because I had it out of love for someone I love. I didn't have it just for me, but for someone I really love. I promise you, Mir, you're going to be like a second mom to this kid. Hey, who's going to babysit while I go back to college, huh?

MIRIAM: Me?

KATE: If you want.

MIRIAM: Of course I do.

KATE: Good, because now that I have someone who needs me, my days as popcorn girl are over.

MIRIAM: So what are we going to name her?

KATE: I was thinking of calling her Miriam.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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